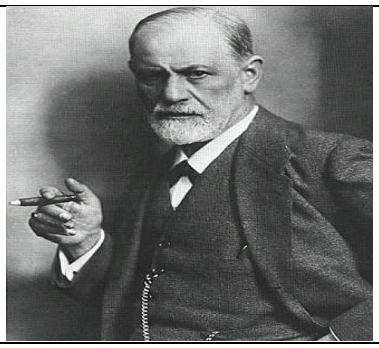
DEFENSE MECHANISMS

Objectives

At the end of this lecture students will be able to:

- Define the term defense mechanism.
- Describe the types of defense mechanisms.
- Recognize healthy and unhealthy defense mechanism.



DEFINITION

Defense mechanisms are psychological strategies used usually at the unconscious level to protect ego from anxiety or guilt which arising from unacceptable thoughts or feelings.

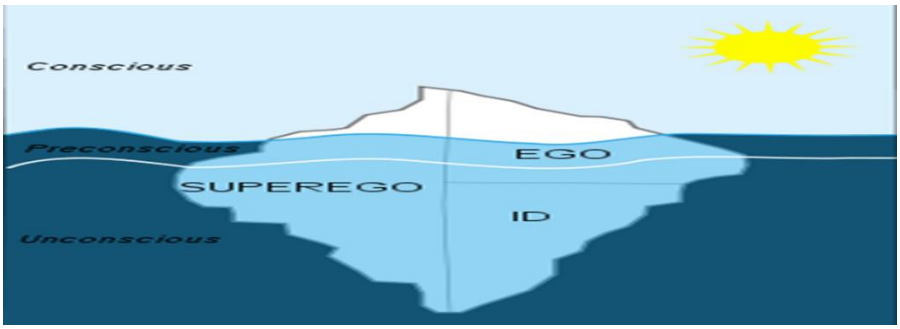
PURPOSE:

Self-security protection
Anxiety or fear reduction
Mental conflict resolution
Esteem (self) protection

Defense mechanism are used to reduce anxiety or resolve conflict by modifying or changing one's behaviors. Use of defense mechanism is a normal process of adjustment. However sometimes use of these defense mechanisms, can also interfere with proper decision making which may give rise to mental disorders. Also, known as mental mechanism.

Ego Defense Mechanisms. Freud believed that the self, or ego, uses **ego defense mechanisms**, which are methods of attempting to protect the self and cope with basic drives or emotionally painful thoughts, feelings, or events.

LEVELS OF MIND



Freud classified all mental contents and operations into three levels.

1) Conscious level:

The contents of the conscious mind include all the things that we are actively aware of at any given moment.

Ex: At this moment, you might be consciously aware of the information you are reading, the sound of the music you are listening to, or a conversation you are having.

2) Preconscious level:

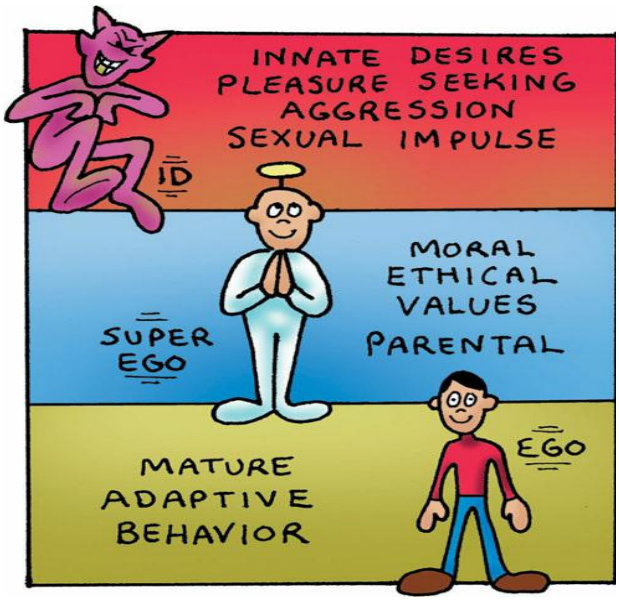
- It includes all memories that may have been forgotten or are not in present awareness but, with attention, can readily be recalled into consciousness.
- **Ex:** you might not be consciously thinking about memories from your high school graduation, but that is information that you could easily bring into the conscious mind if you need this.

3) Unconscious level:

- It is a reservoir of feelings, thoughts, urges, and memories that outside of our conscious awareness. Most of its contents are unacceptable or unpleasant, such as feelings of pain, anxiety, or conflict.
- According to Freud, the unconscious continues to influence our behavior and experience, even though we are unaware of these underlying influences.
- The unconscious can include repressed feelings, hidden memories, habits, thoughts, desires, and reactions.

- ***Freud's components of personality (Structure of personality)***

Freud organized the structure of the personality into three major components: the id, ego, and superego. They are distinguished by their unique functions and different characteristics.



1- Id

The id is the locus of instinctual drives—the "pleasure principle." Present at birth, it endows the infant with instinctual drives that seek to satisfy needs and achieve immediate gratification.

2-Ego

The ego, also called the rational self or the "reality principle". The ego experiences the reality of the external world, adapts to it, and responds to it. A primary function of the ego is to maintain harmony among the external world, the id, and the superego.

3-Superego

It is identified as the "perfection principle." internalizes the values and morals set by primary caregivers. Derived from a system of rewards and punishments,

- ☒ Sigmund Freud identified the ego as the reality component of the personality that governs problem solving and rational thinking. As the level of anxiety increases, the strength of the ego is tested. Anna Freud identified several defense mechanisms which used either consciously or unconsciously as protective devices for the ego in an effort to relieve mild to moderate anxiety.
- ☒ Defense mechanisms become maladaptive when an individual uses them to such a degree that interfere with the ability to deal with reality, with

interpersonal relations, or with occupational performance and may lead to signs of deviation from mental health.

COMMON EXAMPLES OF DEFENSE MECHANISMS

1. **Compensation**

Overachievement in one area to offset real or perceived deficiencies in another area

Also. Covering up a real or perceived weakness by emphasizing a trait one considers more desirable

- **Ex:** A physically handicapped boy is unable to participate in football, so he compensates by becoming a great scholar.

2. **Conversion**

Expression of an emotional conflict through the development of a physical symptom, usually sensorimotor in nature

***also*, is** a mechanism by which emotional conflicts are channeled into physical symptoms or physical illness.

Ex: A young child who witnesses a crime became blind.

3. **Denial**

Failure to acknowledge an unbearable condition; failure to admit the reality of a situation or how one enables the problem to continue

Denial: is the unconscious refusal to face or acknowledge the existence of a real painful situation or feelings associated with it.

Ex: A psychiatric patient tells the nurse "I have no problem".

Ex: Diabetic patient eating chocolate candy.

Ex: The woman who miscarries denies that she has lost the baby and continues to wear maternity clothes.

1. **Displacement**

Ventilation of intense feelings toward persons less threatening than the one who aroused those feelings

Displacement: is the transferring of feeling from one target to another that is considered less threatening. Although the feelings are shifted, their original cause remains the same.

Ex: A person is angry with the boss; he may go home and become angry with the family member or kicks his cat.
Ex: A mother may yell at her child because she is angry with her husband.

2. **Fixation**

Immobilization of a portion of the personality resulting from unsuccessful completion of tasks in a developmental stage.

• It also refers to the point in the individual‘s development at which certain aspects of the emotional development do not advance. The reasons are not clear, but this arrest appears to develop from the inability of the individual to solve problems that occurred during the specific phase of development at which progress ceased or stopped.

3. **Identification**

Modeling actions and opinions of influential others while searching for identity, or aspiring to reach a personal, social, or occupational goal

Identification: An attempt to increase self-worth by acquiring certain attributes, values, and characteristics of an individual one admires.
Ex: A teenage girl emulates the style of dress of a popular female star.
Ex: Nursing student becoming a critical care nurse because this is the specialty of an instructor she admires

4. **Projection**

Unconscious blaming of unacceptable inclinations or thoughts on an external object

Or Projection: The person rejects unwanted characteristics of self and assigns them to others.
Ex: A man who is late for work states "my wife forgot to set the alarm, so, I overslept"
Ex: The client experiencing paranoia blames others for disliking him.

5. **Rationalization**

Excusing own behavior to avoid guilt, responsibility, conflict, anxiety, or loss of self-respect

or **Rationalization: It** is the attempt to make excuses or formulate logical reasons to justify unacceptable feelings or behaviors to obtain social approval.
Ex: A lady who cannot afford to buy a new dress tells her friend “I would love to have this dress, but I don't think the color suits me.
Ex: Man says he beats his wife because she does not listen to him.

6. **Reaction formation**

Acting the opposite of what one thinks or feels

Reaction formation: is the prevention of unacceptable or undesirable thoughts or behaviors from being expressed by exaggerating opposite thoughts or behaviors to defense against social punishment.

Ex: A woman, who dislikes her mother in low, may act very politely toward her.

Ex: Woman who never wanted to have children becomes a supermom

Ex: The college student who feels angry and hostile toward her professor is overtly friendly and agreeable in class.

7. **Regression**

Moving back to a previous developmental stage to feel safe or have needs met.

Or **Regression:** Responding to stress by retreating to an earlier level of development and the comfort measures associated with that level of functioning

Ex: Four years old child begins to suck his thumb and wet bed shortly after the birth of his sibling.

Ex: A 5-year-old asks for a bottle when new baby brother is being fed

8. **Repression**

Excluding emotionally painful or anxiety-provoking thoughts and feelings from conscious awareness

or **Repression:** Involuntary pushing of unpleasant and painful thoughts, feelings, and impulses into the unconscious.

Ex: A teenage boy can't remember driving the car when involved in an accident in which his best friend was killed.

Ex: Woman has no memory before age 7, when she was removed from abusive parents.

9. **Sublimation**

Substituting a socially acceptable activity for an impulse that is unacceptable

Or **Sublimation:** Rechanneling of unacceptable drives or impulses (anger and hostility) into activities that are constructive (exercise and creative work).

Ex: A mother whose son was killed by a drunk driver channels her anger and energy into being the president of the local chapter of Mothers Against Drunk Drivers.

Ex: Person who has quit smoking sucks on hard candy when the urge to smoke arises

Ex: Person goes for a 15-minute walk when tempted to eat junk food

substitution replacing the desired gratification with one that is more readily available.

Ex: Woman who would like to have her own children opens a day care center

10.Suppression

Conscious exclusion of unacceptable thoughts and feelings from conscious awareness.

Or **Suppression:** voluntary (consciously) exclusion of thoughts, feeling or experiences from the conscious mind (voluntary forgetting).

Ex: A woman who is depressed bout divorce tells the nurse "I just don't want to talk about the divorce; there is nothing I can do about it any way".

Ex: Student decides not to think about a parent's illness to study for a test

Ex: Woman tells a friend she cannot think about her son's death right now.

Ex: A rape victim attempts to forget the incident to report it to the proper authorities.

11.Undoing

Exhibiting acceptable behavior to make up for or negate unacceptable behavior

Ex: A person who cheats on a spouse brings to her a bouquet of roses.

Ex: Man, who is ruthless in business donates large amounts of money to charity

12.Isolation

Separation an unacceptable feeling idea or impulse that forms one's thoughts.

Ex: A physician can isolate his feelings about the eventual death of a terminally ill cancer client by focusing his attention instead on the chemotherapy, so he focuses on the treatment, not to the prognosis.

Ex: a person with a particularly stressful job may use isolation to separate their work life from their family life, avoiding the stress affecting their relationships.

13.Symbolization

An external object becomes an outward representation of an internal idea, attitude or feeling.

Ex: the engagement ring symbolizes love and a commitment to another person.

14.Introjection

Integrating belief & values of another individual into one's owns ego structure or unconscious internalization of the qualities of an object or person. It may lead to serious distorted adaptations when guilty feeling starts to function.

Ex: If a nurse fails to get sufficient satisfaction in her job, instead of blaming her supervision or her workers she may feel she is inadequate.

Ex: A depressed man who incorporates the negative feelings and hatred of his estranged wife, who recently filed for divorce.

15.Humor

Overt expression of unacceptable impulses by using humor in a manner, which doesn't produce unpleasantness in self or others

defense mechanisms among schizophrenic patients include the following:

- Projection: A schizophrenic patient on a psychiatric ward may accuse another patient of wanting to harm him because he feels aggressive toward this person.
- Displacement: A psychotic individual may try to punch a smaller person rather than the individual whom he is angry at, because he fears the other, larger person.
- Reaction Formation: When a schizophrenic patient professes to enjoy group therapy even though it actually makes him very nervous to speak with others in a group setting.
- Regression when an adult schizophrenic sleeps with a teddy bear.
- Denial
- Repression

Defense mechanisms common in substance abuse

- Denial
- Isolation
- Rationalization

- Projection

<u>Defense mechanisms common in OCD</u>

- Reaction Formation
- Undoing
- Isolation